



The Clock, Not the Calendar

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 The old grow careful with money, and the usual explanation is that they have less heart for the gamble. The young chase the volatile stock; the old retreat into the safe bond; the spirit cools as the body does. There is real ground here, and it would be careless to wave it away. Portfolio studies do find that the share of stocks an investor holds falls with age while the share of bonds rises, and the pattern holds across different cohorts and different markets, which suggests something steadier than a passing mood. The conventional reading takes this curve as a kind of slow forfeit of nerve.

2 It is a tempting story because it flatters the young and consoles the old, and because it fits a feeling everyone has had. But the curve is not a record of fading nerve; it is a record of arithmetic. [Antithesis] A sixty-five-year-old American has roughly twenty years of remaining life expectancy; an eighty-five-year-old has roughly six. Twenty years is enough time to ride out a crash and earn the loss back. Six years is not. A person who buys the safer bond at eighty-five has not lost the appetite for risk so much as run out of the one resource that makes risk survivable, which is time.

3 Notice what this does to the word careful. We had been using it to mean timid, a smallness of character. On the new reading it means something nearer to numerate: a clear-eyed estimate of how long is left to recover from a fall. [Diction] Loss aversion itself does not deepen with age. The finding that losses weigh about twice as heavily as equal gains is one of the most replicated results in the study of decision-making, and it shows up at every age, in the young as much as the old. What changes is not how much a loss stings. It is how much room remains to undo one.

4 If this were really a story about age, age itself would have to be doing the work, and it is not. [Logos] The neater proof is a cruel little experiment. Put young adults in a laboratory, shorten their sense of how much time they have left, change nothing else, and their taste for the risky bet drops too. The horizon moved; the birth date did not. [Telegraphic sentence] Carstensen's work on how a shrinking sense of time reshapes what people want points the same way: when the runway looks short, goals contract toward the sure thing. It is the clock that governs us here, not the calendar.

5 None of this makes the picture tidy. Wealth muddies it badly: high-income older adults often keep aggressive portfolios while poorer ones turn sharply cautious, which means money and security, not years, may be doing much of the steering. [Concession] And a generation that lived through a crash carries the fear forward for decades, so history leaves its own thumbprint on nerve. The economists publish in journals most of us will never open. What survives the qualifications is a smaller, stranger thought, and it is not really about the old at all. We treat the caution of age as something that happens to other people, later. It is only the visible end of a sum every one of us is already doing, mostly without looking, every time we guess at how much time is left.

Devices, and why they are here:

Antithesis (paragraph 2): “But the curve is not a record of fading nerve; it is a record of arithmetic.”

The line sets fading nerve against arithmetic in balanced, parallel form to pivot the whole piece: it names the conventional reading and its replacement in one stroke. Choosing antithesis here, rather than a softer transition, makes the reframe feel like a correction, not an addition.

Diction (paragraph 3): “On the new reading it means something nearer to numerate: a clear-eyed estimate of how long is left to recover from a fall.”

The writer holds one ordinary word, careful, up to the light and swaps its connotation from timid to numerate. Naming the word choice directly lets students see how an argument can be won by reweighting a single word rather than by adding evidence.

Logos (paragraph 4): “If this were really a story about age, age itself would have to be doing the work, and it is not.”

The laboratory experiment is offered as the decisive proof: shorten perceived time in the young, hold age constant, and risk-taking falls. The author reaches for clean causal evidence here because the turn rests on cause, that time and not age is doing the work, and only an experiment can carry that weight.

Telegraphic sentence (paragraph 4): “The horizon moved; the birth date did not.”

After the experiment is described, this short clipped sentence lands the inference fast and flat. Its brevity throws weight onto the claim and gives the reader a place to breathe before the next move; naming it telegraphic, not syntax, marks the specific clipped effect.

Concession (paragraph 5): “Wealth muddies it badly: high-income older adults often keep aggressive portfolios while poorer ones turn sharply cautious, which means money and security, not years, may be doing much of the steering.”

The writer grants the opposing complication its real force: wealth, not age, may be doing much of the steering, which genuinely threatens the time-horizon thesis. Conceding this much in good faith, rather than burying it, is what keeps the argument honest instead of triumphant, and it is the granted claim itself that is marked, not a phrase insisting the grant is sincere.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. The relationship between the first paragraph and the second paragraph is best described as one in which the writer first
 - A) presents statistical evidence and then concedes that the evidence is unreliable
 - B) states a personal opinion and then supports it with expert testimony
 - C) raises a popular belief in order to mock it and then dismisses it outright
 - D) lays out the conventional explanation fairly and then replaces its cause with a different one
2. In the third paragraph, the writer's reexamination of the word "careful" serves primarily to
 - A) reframe a trait read as weakness of character into a rational calculation
 - B) concede that the conventional critics were right to call older investors timid
 - C) soften the argument by admitting the key term cannot be defined precisely
 - D) introduce a new statistic about how loss aversion grows over a lifetime

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer D. The first paragraph gives the fading-nerve account real ground, citing the portfolio curve across cohorts and markets, and the second turns on the claim that the curve is arithmetic rather than lost nerve, substituting time remaining as the cause. The option about mockery fails because the writer calls the conventional story tempting and treats it fairly rather than ridiculing it; the option about conceding unreliable evidence inverts the move, since the portfolio data is accepted and reinterpreted, not discredited; the option about personal opinion supported by testimony misreads the structure, since the writer reframes a cause rather than defending a private view.

2. Answer A. The writer moves careful from meaning timid, a smallness of character, to meaning numerate, a clear estimate of time left to recover, which converts a supposed character flaw into a rational response. The option about conceding timidity inverts the writer's point, since the paragraph denies that reading; the option about an indefinable term is true-sounding but unsupported, as the writer redefines the word rather than calling it undefinable; the option about a new statistic misreads the paragraph, which actually states that loss aversion does NOT deepen with age.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer spends the entire first paragraph granting the conventional explanation real evidence before turning against it in the second. How does conceding the other side so fully change the way the reframing lands?
2. The piece argues that perceived time remaining, not chronological age, drives the shift toward caution. Which single piece of evidence in the essay does the most work to support that claim, and why is it more persuasive than the others?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. A strong answer notes that the concession is strategic. By granting that the portfolio curve is real, holds across cohorts and markets, and looks like more than a mood, the writer removes the easy objection that this is a contrarian dismissal of the data. Having accepted the evidence in full, the writer is free to reinterpret its cause, so the claim that the curve is arithmetic rather than lost nerve reads as a fairer reading of the same facts rather than a rejection of them.
2. A strong answer identifies the laboratory experiment in the fourth paragraph as the load-bearing evidence: young adults whose sense of remaining time is shortened, with age held constant, become more risk-averse. This is more persuasive than the actuarial figures or the portfolio curve because those are correlations that age could still explain, while the experiment isolates time horizon as the cause by changing it directly and leaving the birth date untouched. The strongest response connects this to the closing line that it is the clock, not the calendar, that governs the choice.

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The writer argues that what looks like the timidity of age is better understood as a rational response to shrinking time, and closes by suggesting that all of us are quietly making the same calculation about how much time is left. Defend, challenge, or qualify the claim that behavior we tend to attribute to a person's age or character is better explained by the constraints they actually face. Use your own knowledge, observation, or reading to develop your position.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students may read the first paragraph's evidence as the writer's own settled position and conclude the essay endorses the fading-nerve explanation. The data is granted on purpose so the writer can turn against its usual interpretation; conceding the evidence is not the same as accepting the conventional cause.
- Students often mislabel the pivot sentence in paragraph two as simple contrast or juxtaposition. It is antithesis: fading nerve and arithmetic are set in balanced, parallel grammatical form, which is what distinguishes antithesis from two ideas merely placed near each other.
- Students may treat the concession in the final paragraph about wealth as a sign the writer has abandoned the time-horizon argument. It is granted ground, an honest complication the writer raises and then moves past, not a retraction of the thesis.
- Students may say loss aversion grows with age because older people act more cautiously. The essay states the opposite: loss aversion is roughly constant across ages, and what changes is the time left to recover from a loss, not how much the loss stings.

AP exam alignment:

This opener teaches the Concession-then-Rebuttal structure at full strength, where the opposing case is granted real evidence before the argument turns on cause rather than on new data. It gives students a clean specimen for distinguishing antithesis from loose contrast, for seeing how diction can carry an argument by reweighting a single word, and for telling correlational evidence from the causal experiment that the thesis actually needs.